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Ex-prosecutors: Boutros has hurt the office

Group of more than 100 releases letter decrying actions by US attorney

By Jason Meisner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

More than a hundred former Chicago federal prosecutors released a letter Monday saying actions taken by U.S. Attorney Andrew Boutros and other leaders have “tarnished the reputation of the United States Attorney’s Office.”

The group, which includes former U.S. Attorney Scott Lassar

and onetime acting U.S. Attorney Gary Shapiro, also said it is concerned that “once-forbidden political considerations are infecting prosecutorial decisions,” and called on Boutros — who was nominated for the top post by President Donald Trump last year — to “stand above and apart from political fealty.”

The letter cites an ongoing exodus of leadership from the office, as well as grand jury “irregulari-



Boutros

ties” and “breaches of trust” with judges that have arisen out of Operation Midway Blitz as evidence of “a failure of leadership in the office we deeply respect.”

The letter does not call for Boutros to resign.

“For decades, our former office earned a reputation for winning significant cases while playing by the rules. We hope that the next few months will provide an opportunity to begin an effort to restore this reputation,” stated the letter, signed by 111 former members of the office. “That, however, will require candor from (Boutros); the cour-

age to stand above and apart from political fealty; and a willingness to address the failures that have occurred. It will require action, not mere words.”

The sharp criticism comes days after acting U.S. Attorney General Todd Blanche, a former private attorney for Trump who’s been nominated by the president for the permanent attorney general position, came to Boutros’ defense in a lengthy social media post that praised him for “steadfastly” advancing the White House’s mission to make the city “safe for the American people.”

“This department fully supports U.S. Attorney Boutros and his efforts to combat violent crime, drug trafficking, immigration violations, and fraud, and we look forward to more great work from his office,” Blanche said Thursday in a statement posted on X.

Blanche said Boutros has increased indictments by 34% over the prior administration in 2025, and by 61% so far this year, although he did not give details. He specifically mentioned cases against the Sinaloa cartel and weapons charges

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Israel, Iran appear to pause attacks

Both countries warn of retaliation if other renews hostile acts

By Jon Gambrell
and Melanie Lidman
ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI, United Arab Emirates — Israel and Iran appeared to back away from further strikes Monday, hours after they traded fire for the first time since the U.S. agreed to a ceasefire with Tehran two months ago. Both countries warned that they were ready to launch retaliatory attacks if provoked.

The renewed hostilities raised concerns that the Middle East could plunge back into a full-scale war.

Since the U.S. and Israel began striking Iran on Feb. 28, the war has shaken the global economy, driven up energy prices around the world and made many basics, including food, more expensive. Officials have been unable to turn the April ceasefire into a deal to permanently end the conflict.

The new attacks prompted President Donald Trump to call for an immediate stop to fighting between Israel and Iran. He also promised that a final deal to end the war in the Middle East was on the way, although the president’s predictions of an agreement with Iran have frequently failed to materialize.

Soon after, the Iranian military’s joint command issued a statement that said it was halting offensive strikes. The statement said further “aggression and hostile acts” by Israel and its supporters, including in southern Lebanon, would be met with “much more severe and crushing measures than before.”

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, speaking in a video-taped statement, implied that the current round of fighting was over. But he also warned that if Iran “makes the mistake and returns to attacking us, we will respond with force.”

Netanyahu said Israel is continu-

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Sasha Vry, a farm operations worker at Farm Zero, describes the variety of edible flowers growing in a vertical farm on the 18th floor of an office building at 30 N. LaSalle St. in Chicago on May 12. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

A growth opportunity for vacant Loop offices

Downtown vertical farms offer chance to produce healthy food in center of city

By Jerry Wu
FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Imagine walking into one of the towering buildings in the Chicago Loop.

You ride the elevator up a dozen floors. When the doors open, a faint earthy smell greets you. Stepping off the elevator, instead of rows of cubicles, you find racks of vegetables growing under LED lights in the office.

That’s the vision Russell Steinberg has for downtown Chicago office spaces.

Steinberg is the founder of Farm Zero, one of a few vertical farming companies around Chicago. Nearly a decade ago, vertical farming became part of an agricultural technology craze, introducing a new way of growing crops indoors using stacked trays set up under artificial lighting, hydroponics and tightly controlled environments.

But since then, the industry has seen mixed success. A handful of companies have shuttered because of unsustainable business models amid high energy

and infrastructure costs, urban agriculture experts say.

Despite that, Steinberg believes Farm Zero has one major advantage: the location of his farm.

“We need to produce healthy food inside the center of the city,” said Steinberg, who grew up in Riverwoods in Lake County.

Most vertical farms around Chicago have historically operated in large warehouses away from downtown, according to Kevin Erickson, an urban agriculture instructor at Loyola University Chicago. Farm Zero’s facility

is on the 18th floor of an office tower at 30 N. LaSalle St.

“My impression is that they are one of the first, if not the first, downtown Loop-based operations distributing mostly within the downtown Chicago area,” Erickson said.

Since construction finished in 2024, the farm’s central location has allowed it to partner with several companies headquartered in the Loop, including caterers, healthcare partners and restaur-

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Indiana county eager to host Bears games

While the Lake County Council has shared its enthusiasm with the recent news that the Chicago Bears are moving ahead with a potential stadium in Hammond, it will still take time to pass the required taxes for the project, officials said. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Fuel prices alter summer boating

The National Marine Manufacturers Association said its conversations with boaters indicate that most still plan to head out on the water this year, but in some cases, elevated gas prices are curtailing their plans. **Business**



Samuel Wilson, creator of the cannabis and hemp brand “Support Your Local Weed Man,” at his cannabis cafe, Prohibition THCaFe, on Thursday. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Bill targets unlicensed intoxicating hemp sellers

Illinois law that would halt the practice awaits signature by Pritzker

By Robert McCoppin
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

After federal law legalized hemp in 2018, Samuel Wilson co-founded Prohibition THCaFe, which sells hemp-derived THC-infused edibles and beverages on the Near South Side. For the informal 420 cannabis holiday on April 20, the cafe partnered with Harold’s Chicken to sell infused wings, with customers lining up down the block.

But Wilson’s cafe may be put out of business by both a new federal law banning sales of intoxicating hemp and a proposed Illinois measure, approved by lawmakers, that would ban hemp sales other than by state-licensed dispensaries. The bill, which would have to be signed by Gov. JB Pritzker to take effect, is meant to get rid of unscrupulous shops that sell untested, unlimited amounts of hemp to minors. It also would close businesses like that of Wilson, who says he sells only tested, high-quality products to those 21 and over.

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